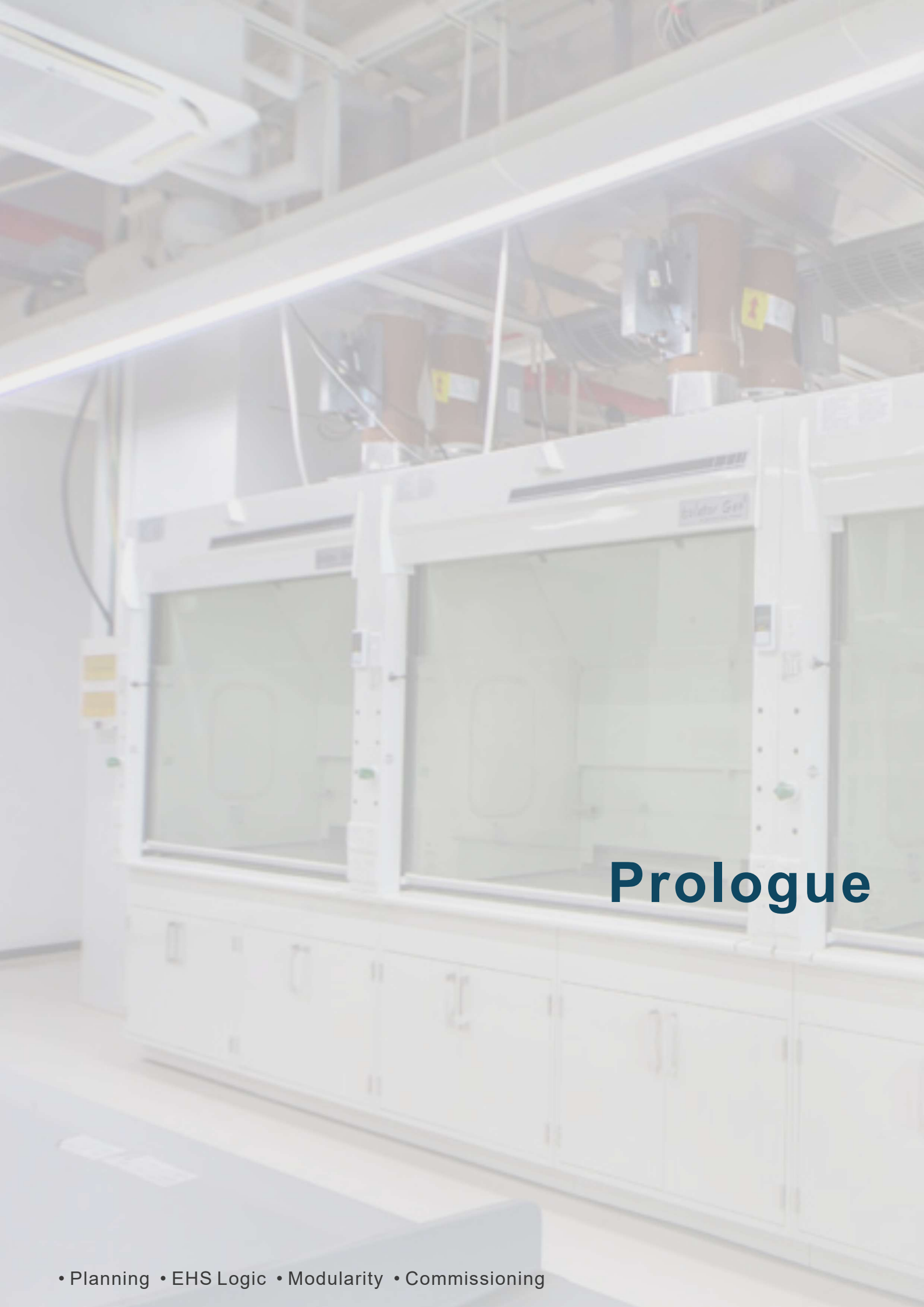




L2-7

The Emergence, Purpose and Limits of Laboratory Modularity

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Prologue

• Planning • EHS Logic • Modularity • Commissioning



Few concepts in laboratory planning have become as widely accepted as modularity.

Whether the discussion involves new facilities, future expansions, technology upgrades, or long-term growth strategies, modularity is often presented as a self-evident solution. It is commonly associated with flexibility, scalability, adaptability, and extended facility life cycles. In many cases, its value is assumed long before its underlying logic is examined.

Yet an important question is rarely asked.

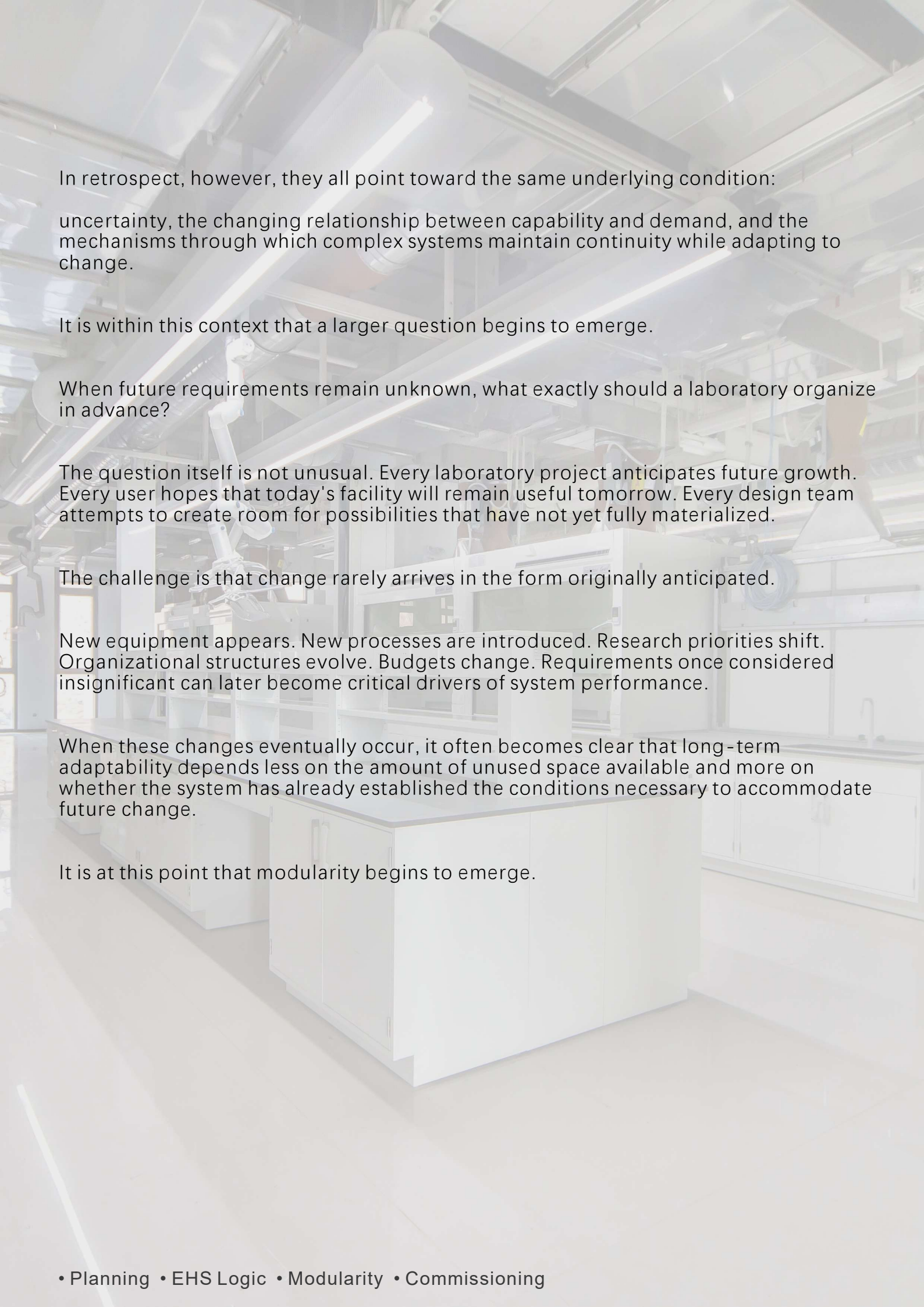
Why do laboratory systems repeatedly move toward modularity?

If modularity is merely a design methodology, its significance would be limited to the design process. If it is simply an engineering strategy, then the discussion would largely revolve around construction, procurement, and delivery. However, throughout years of observing laboratory projects across different scales and disciplines, I have gradually come to believe that modularity represents something far more fundamental.

Looking back, many of the topics discussed throughout the L2 series now appear less independent than they once seemed.

L2-3 explored redundancy and demonstrated how systems often reserve capabilities in anticipation of uncertain future demands. L2-4 examined furniture and system relationships, revealing that much of the change within a laboratory occurs at the configuration layer rather than within the underlying capability structure. L2-5 showed that operational boundaries are rarely fixed, and that the distinction between spaces continuously shifts as requirements evolve. L2-6 further demonstrated how operational reality persistently reshapes ideal systems, creating ongoing pressure for adaptation.

At first glance, these appear to be separate discussions.



In retrospect, however, they all point toward the same underlying condition:

uncertainty, the changing relationship between capability and demand, and the mechanisms through which complex systems maintain continuity while adapting to change.

It is within this context that a larger question begins to emerge.

When future requirements remain unknown, what exactly should a laboratory organize in advance?

The question itself is not unusual. Every laboratory project anticipates future growth. Every user hopes that today's facility will remain useful tomorrow. Every design team attempts to create room for possibilities that have not yet fully materialized.

The challenge is that change rarely arrives in the form originally anticipated.

New equipment appears. New processes are introduced. Research priorities shift. Organizational structures evolve. Budgets change. Requirements once considered insignificant can later become critical drivers of system performance.

When these changes eventually occur, it often becomes clear that long-term adaptability depends less on the amount of unused space available and more on whether the system has already established the conditions necessary to accommodate future change.

It is at this point that modularity begins to emerge.

The more I examined this pattern, however, the more I realized that modularity may not be the answer at all. Instead, it appears to be the result of something deeper.

Modularity does not emerge in isolation, nor is it simply a design preference. Rather, it can be understood as an organizational response developed by complex systems facing persistent uncertainty. Service spines, utility nodes, repeatable planning units, expandable infrastructure networks, and standardized service strategies may appear different on the surface, yet they all attempt to address a common challenge: how to preserve stable capabilities while demands continue to change.

If this interpretation is correct, then modularity may not standardize spaces at all. What it standardizes may instead be capabilities. Likewise, a module may represent something more significant than a room, a furniture arrangement, or a service corridor. It may represent a stable capability platform that can be repeatedly deployed, recombined, and adapted as conditions evolve.

This perspective immediately raises another question.

If modularity helps laboratories accommodate change, where do its limits begin? Can every challenge be addressed through modular structures? Does every form of flexibility originate from modularity? Or is modularity itself only one component within a larger organizational logic?

These questions do not have simple answers.

The purpose of L2-7 is therefore not to establish another definition of modularity. Instead, it seeks to return to the conditions from which modularity emerges and to examine why it appears, what problems it attempts to solve, and where its boundaries ultimately lie.



To explore these questions, L2-7 will be organized into four chapters.

Chapter 1 — Why Does Modularity Emerge?

Why complex laboratory systems repeatedly develop modular tendencies.

Chapter 2 — What Is a Module?

When discussing modules, are we truly discussing spaces, equipment, or something more fundamental?

Chapter 3 — How Does Modularity Accommodate Change?

How modular structures maintain stability while demands continue to evolve.

Chapter 4 — What Are the Limits of Modularity?

What modularity can solve, and where its boundaries begin to appear.

Ultimately, modularity may not be the objective pursued by complex laboratory systems. It may instead be a recurring outcome produced by systems attempting to remain functional in the face of uncertainty. If that is true, then the real question is no longer how modularity is implemented, but why laboratory systems with different functions, different users, and different operational realities repeatedly converge toward similar organizational forms.

Understanding that question is where the discussion begins.

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